

Tons of colleges require a supplemental essay that essentially asks, “Why do you want to major in what you want to major in?”

Two quick tips:

1. It’s worth spending some time on these essays to make sure your answer complements your personal statement. What do I mean? If your personal statement is all about business and your “Why Major” college essay is all about dance, admissions readers might be like, “Whaaaaat?” So make sure they make sense together. Also,
2. Just because you picked a major for this essay, it doesn’t mean you 100% can’t change it later. In many cases, you can. (Important: This varies from school to school, so if you’re unsure, find out.) It can help to choose a major as a placeholder, though, as it makes this essay a LOT easier to write.

WHAT DOES A “WHY THIS COLLEGE MAJOR” ESSAY LOOK LIKE?

Like this:

Why are you drawn to the area(s) of study you indicated earlier in this application? (You may share with us a skill or concept that you found challenging and rewarding to learn, or any experiences beyond coursework that may have broadened your interest.)

Or this:

Students at Yale have plenty of time to explore their academic interests before committing to one or more major fields of study. Many students either modify their original academic direction or change their minds entirely. As of this moment, what academic areas seem to fit your interests or goals most comfortably? Please indicate up to three from the list provided. Why do these areas appeal to you?

In short: Why do you want to study what you want to study?

A BRIEF, STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE TO WRITING YOUR “WHY THIS MAJOR” ESSAY

Step #1: Imagine a mini-movie of the moments that led you to your interest and create a simple, bullet-point outline:

Why Biology?

Elementary school: Getting my first dinosaur toy and reading dinosaur books

Middle school: Visiting museums, seeing water under a microscope

High school: Doing online research, getting an internship where we analyzed brainwaves and dissected a stingray

Step #2: Put your moments (aka the “scenes” of your mini-movie) in chronological order, as it’ll help you see how your interests developed. It also makes it easier to write transitions.

Pro Tip: If you’re writing a shorter essay (e.g., 100-150 words), try writing one scene per sentence. If you’re writing a medium-length (e.g., 250-300 words) essay, try one scene per short paragraph.

Step #3: Decide if you want to include a specific thesis that explicitly states your central argument—in this case, what you want to study and why. This thesis can come at the beginning, middle, or end of your essay.

THREE “WHY MAJOR” ESSAY EXAMPLES

WHY ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING?

My decision to major in Electrical Engineering was inspired by my desire to improve security through technology. When I lived in Mexico, my father’s restaurant security system lacked the ability to protect our property from robbers, who would break in multiple times a year. Thanks to the influence of my cousin, who now studies Autonomous Systems, I developed an interest in electrical engineering. I am inspired to not only improve my father’s security

system, but contributing to security innovations for larger companies and perhaps, one day, national security. (89 words)

Outline:

Why Electrical Engineering?

Thesis: I want to improve security through technology

Robbers broke into Dad's restaurant.

My cousin taught me about Autonomous Systems.

In the future: work with large companies or on national security.

Here's a medium-length example with the thesis at the end:

WHY GENDER AND SEXUALITY STUDIES?

My interest in Gender and Sexuality Studies was sparked in my eighth-grade Civics class when we studied topics pertaining to sexual equality. I went into the class knowing I believed women had a right to make choices for their own bodies and that view remained the same, but I discovered the complexity of abortion debates. I challenged myself by thinking about the disparity between actual and potential personhood and the moral rights of unconscious lives. If pregnancy had the same consequences for men as it does women, how might the debate be different? Would this debate even exist?

A year later, I shadowed an OB/GYN at a nearby hospital. On my first shift, I watched an incarcerated woman receive a post-partum exam after giving birth in her cell toilet with just Advil, and the issues discussed in Civics suddenly became urgent and real.

My school projects have often focused on reproductive rights. I've spent numerous hours delving into summaries of Supreme Court cases on abortion and contraception, and am even known as the "Tampon Fairy" at school because I frequently restock the school bathrooms with tampons and condoms.

I'm interested in exploring how Gender and Sexuality Studies connect to Public Health and Reproductive Biology, as well as Public Policy and Law. The interdisciplinary nature of this major will allow me to investigate many other areas of study and create a more nuanced understanding of how this particular field interacts with our world and society. (246 words)

Outline:

Why Gender and Sexuality Studies:

- Eighth-grade Civics class conversations
- Shadowing OB/GYN at a nearby hospital and seeing woman receive post-partum exam
- Being the school “tampon fairy” (restocking school bathrooms with tampons and condoms)
- School projects on reproductive rights
- Thesis: name my major and briefly say why

You can also use a hook to grab your reader’s attention. Here’s a medium-length example that does this:

WHY NEUROSCIENCE?

Imagine all the stars in the universe. The brain has a thousand times the number of synapses, making neurological errors a near certainty. I learned this fact firsthand as a 14-year-old when I suffered from sleepless nights because of an uncomfortable, indescribable feeling in my leg. It took months of appointments and tests to be told it was a condition called cortical dysplasia. Even after the diagnosis, there is no cure.

I am lucky. My condition does not severely affect my quality of life. However, I know this is not the case for everyone. After this experience, I took AP Biology and attended a neuroscience program, which reinforced the subject as my future calling. One of the most impactful lectures discussed the plight of healthcare in developing nations. Newborns with extreme neurological deficits are common, but finding treatments is not. Without prenatal care, this is becoming a growing epidemic, leaving millions of children helpless.

With a degree in neuroscience, I will gain a strong understanding of neural tube development and neuronal migration in infants. I will then become a neurologist, specializing in pediatric care. I hope to work for humanitarian organizations, such as Doctors Without Borders, in Africa, where HIV and polio are rampant, as are numerous other diseases.

Imagine the stars once more. From across the world, I will look at the same stars in the future, as I help children secure the ability to not only look at the stars but do much more. (247 words)

Outline:

Why Neuroscience:

Hook: Connect the number of stars to the number of connections in the brain (and maybe mention cortical dysplasia)

AP Bio + neuroscience program: learning about healthcare in developing nations

Thesis: say why neuroscience (get specific) and what I'll do with the degree

Return to the opening (stars) and look to the future

WHAT TO DO IF YOU'RE UNSURE OF YOUR MAJOR OR CHOOSING "UNDECIDED" ON YOUR APPLICATION

Even if you're unsure of your major, you might still research and select 1-3 areas of interest and describe how you became interested in each. If possible, say how the different fields connect.

Fun fact: Two of the essay examples on this page were written by students who weren't totally certain of their major. But you won't be able to guess which ones they are.

HOW TO WRITE YOUR "WHY MAJOR" ESSAY USING A THEMATIC THREAD

The example below establishes in the first paragraph a thematic thread: *storytelling*. The second paragraph then explains how her particular major would take her storytelling to the next level. Take a look:

Why Literary Arts or Modern Culture and Media?

My whole life, storytelling has shaped me. When I lived in London, my parents would read me The Lion King every night until I'd memorized the whole book. In elementary school, I would curl up in my bed, warm lamplight making my room golden, listening to my dad bring to life classics like Wilderness Champion and Tom Sawyer. Later, I found audio storytelling, laughing hysterically at Wait Wait Don't Tell Me on the car ride to school and connecting

to a radio network of humanity through This American Life. It wasn't long before I got hooked on visual narratives, mesmerized by the cinematic intensity of Whiplash and the whimsical world of Moonrise Kingdom, alternate realities I could explore as if they were my own. By high school, I was creating my own array of stories through satirical school newspaper articles, analysis of mise-en-scene in film class, podcasting, and my own locally broadcasted radio series.

A concentration in the Literary Arts or Modern Culture and Media is the next step in my life of storytelling. The dynamic world of connection and vulnerability a well-told story can create is what continues to fascinate me. At Brown, I would explore how engaging narratives have been told in the past and can be innovated in the future through new digital platforms. Whether researching radio's historical impact on public opinion during World War II or the Vietnam War, developing screenplays, producing my own documentary, or learning from Writers-In-Residence, I hope to pioneer networks of connection.
(250 words)

Outline:

Part 1: Establish "storytelling" as a thematic thread

Mom and Dad reading me *The Lion King* before bed
Dad reading me *Wilderness Champion* and *Tom Sawyer*
Audio storytelling: *Wait Wait Don't Tell Me*, *This American Life*
Visual storytelling: *Whiplash*, *Moonrise Kingdom*
Creating my own stories: school newspaper articles, film class analysis, podcasting, local radio series

Part 2: Why Literary Arts or Modern Culture and Media

The next step in my journey
Values: connection and vulnerability
Explore history of storytelling (past) + digital platforms (future)
Ways I might do this: studying the impact of radio during wars, writing screenplays, producing a documentary, or learning from Writers-In-Residence
End on the theme of "connection," to tie things together

WHAT IF A SCHOOL ASKS YOU TO DESCRIBE YOUR INTEREST IN SEVERAL POSSIBLE MAJORS?

If writing a short (100-150 word) essay, perhaps describe one interest per sentence. If writing a medium-length (200-250 word) essay, try describing one interest per paragraph.

Here's a short example, written by a student who listed on his application the following areas of interest: Computer Science and Mathematics; Computer Science and Psychology; Electrical Engineering and Computer Science

Having attended college Physics classes every Saturday for a year, I've embraced the wisdom from centuries-old mathematics and the vast potential of computers, a realization I can honor by pursuing Computer Science and Mathematics. Much of my interest in AI lies in its basis in the human brain, which I can pursue in a Psychology concentration. And Electrical Engineering allows me to connect the virtual world with the physical, as I currently do in robotics. Yale will fuel my interdisciplinary interests that stem from my curiosity about connections between the materials and systems in the world around me. (98 words)

Final note: While this may feel pretty straightforward, that's okay. Prioritize content over poetry when writing a short "Why Major" essay.